

# Blind Spot Autobiography Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and the Knower • 20 min

|            |                          |      |                          |
|------------|--------------------------|------|--------------------------|
| Category   | Knowledge and the Knower | Time | 20 min                   |
| Difficulty | Easy                     | ID   | blind-spot-autobiography |

Big idea: Self-knowledge includes awareness of limits.

## Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect Blind Spot Autobiography Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

## Concrete Stimulus Packet

|                                                |                                                                                                                                                                                                            |                                                                                                             |
|------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Blind Spot Autobiography Stimulus A</b>     | Student-facing stimulus 1: A private reflection on one belief students changed without sharing sensitive content. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are. | Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.                    |
| <b>Blind Spot Autobiography Stimulus B</b>     | Student-facing stimulus 2: A 'known unknowns' box for topics students realise they rarely question. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.               | Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.                                            |
| <b>Blind Spot Autobiography Reveal / Twist</b> | Student-facing stimulus 3: A perspective inventory naming communities that make some assumptions feel obvious. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.    | Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Self-knowledge includes awareness of limits. |

## Actual Lesson Questions

| # | Question for students                                                                     |
|---|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | After inspecting Blind Spot Autobiography Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim? |
| 2 | Which exact detail from Blind Spot Autobiography Stimulus A did you use as evidence?      |
| 3 | What did you infer beyond the evidence?                                                   |
| 4 | How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?                                  |
| 5 | What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?                          |
| 6 | Can knowing your bias make you less biased?                                               |

## Ready-to-Use Examples

- A private reflection on one belief students changed without sharing sensitive content.
- A 'known unknowns' box for topics students realise they rarely question.
- A perspective inventory naming communities that make some assumptions feel obvious.

## Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Knowledge and the Knower.

## Activity Steps

1. Students privately complete three prompts: "Something I used to believe", "Something I strongly believe but cannot fully prove", and "Something I may be biased about".
2. Students choose one safe example to discuss with a partner, or keep all examples private.
3. The class builds a list of causes of blind spots: identity, language, friendship group, schooling, emotion, incentives and media.
4. Finish with a one-sentence reflection: "A good knower should..."

## Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

| What I noticed | What I inferred | Evidence | Confidence |
|----------------|-----------------|----------|------------|
|                |                 |          |            |
|                |                 |          |            |
|                |                 |          |            |

## TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: Can knowing your bias make you less biased?
- Is self-knowledge necessary for reliable knowledge?
- When does perspective become distortion?

## Knowledge Questions

- Can knowing your bias make you less biased?
- Is self-knowledge necessary for reliable knowledge?
- When does perspective become distortion?

## Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with a private reflection on one belief students changed without sharing sensitive content. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

## Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...